

Nicolle Bekers, M.A.

Intermediate Team Faculty • Mary, Star of the Sea School
4469 Malia Street, Honolulu, Hawai'i 96821 • Office Phone:
808-734-0208
Office Hours: 2:45-3:15 p.m. (M-F) in Room B23 • Email:
nbekers@starofthesea.org
ALL Teachers: 4thgradeteachers@starofthesea.org



Syllabus: 2026-2027 Grade 4 Science

Welcome to Grade 4! I am excited to partner with you this school year. This syllabus provides an outline of what we will learn, classroom expectations, grading policies, and the support you can expect throughout the school year. We will work together to create a class community where every student is encouraged, challenged, and inspired to grow academically and spiritually.

Mary, Star of the Sea School Mission Statement:

Nurture, Unite, Inspire. We are committed to nurturing each child's curiosity, uniting our classroom in respect and collaboration, and inspiring every student to grow in knowledge, faith, and wonder for the world around them.

Schoolwide Learning Expectations (SLEs): Self-Aware, Confident Individuals; Teachable Life-Long Learners; Active Christians; Responsible Citizens.

Science Course Overview:

Students will build confidence and mastery in physical, life, and earth science through hands-on labs, engineering-design challenges, and inquiry-based learning aligned to the Next Generation Science Standards (NGSS). Units cover engineering & technology, plant and animal structures, energy and communication, shaping landforms, and Earth's features and resources.

Standardized testing: Students take the STAR assessment in fall, winter, and spring to track growth. English-language learners take the WIDA assessment as required.

SCIENCE GRADING POLICY:

- 30% Assessments (Unit Tests and Quizzes)
- 30% Classwork/Lab Work (Daily science notebook & lab activities)
- 20% Projects/Investigations (Engineering design and hands-on labs)
- 10% Homework
- 10% Participation (Discussion, safe lab collaboration)

***Parents, please note:** You will have access to my electronic grade book, via your Beehively account, which will be the method of communicating your child's academic performance. Beehively will serve as the primary source for monitoring grades, missing assignments, and academic progress throughout the school year.

Parent-teacher conferences: Formal conferences after Q1 and Q3 grades post. Additional conferences may be requested by email anytime.

REQUIRED MATERIALS:

Students should bring the following materials to Science each day:

- Composition notebook (Science Notebook)

- Erasable pen, pencil, eraser and highlighter
- Colored pencils
- School-issued iPad (with access to Google Classroom)
- School planner

SUPPLEMENTAL MATERIALS — TEXTBOOK:

- HMH Into Science • Grade 4 (NGSS-aligned)

Daily Schedule:

Please refer to the MSOS Grade 4 daily bell schedule (a hard copy is included in your first-week folder) for exact times. Specials (P.E., Music, Art, Library, and Chapel) rotate on specific days — please check the weekly schedule sent home. Pickup procedures and any late-start / early-release days are in the family handbook and the school calendar.

HOMEWORK POLICY:

As per school policy, students are expected to allocate time for a maximum of 40 minutes of homework per night (MSOS guideline: ~10 minutes per grade). Your child's 4th grade teachers work together to ensure a balanced homework regime. Students record assignments in their planner. Homework and reminders are also posted on Google Classroom. Parents are expected to check the student's planner daily and support time management.

Late work will be accepted; however, submitting on time is important. Late submissions may affect the participation grade.

Tips for supporting homework at home: Set a consistent, quiet study time and place. Read directions together, then step back and let your child try. Ask them to explain the science concept back to you. If a task takes much longer than expected, please note it and email me.

CLASSROOM PROCEDURES & BEHAVIOR EXPECTATIONS:

- Students come to class prepared and ready to learn each day.
- Homework should be completed on time. If circumstances prevent completion, students should communicate with the teacher in advance so an appropriate plan can be made.
- Everyone is encouraged to participate by asking questions, contributing ideas, and seeking clarification.
- We will treat ourselves, one another, and school property with respect and responsibility.

Positive recognition: Students earn recognition through verbal praise, positive notes home, sticker/star acknowledgments, and class-wide rewards (extra recess, class read-aloud pick, review-day celebrations) for consistently showing our expected behaviors.

When expectations are not met (supportive, restorative sequence):

1. Quiet private reminder and reset.
2. Reflection sheet / think-time in class.
3. Loss of a small privilege and a note home.
4. Phone call or email home; if needed, a family meeting with the principal.

The goal is always to help students re-choose kind, respectful, on-task behavior — not to punish.

TECHNOLOGY:

Platforms used in this class: Beehively (grade portal), Google Classroom (assignments), iPads/Chromebooks in class, and NGSS-aligned digital resources.

Digital citizenship: All device use follows the MSOS Technology Acceptable Usage Policy in the family handbook. Any misuse is handled per the school's AUP.

To minimize distractions and maximize learning, communication with students during the school day should be limited to emergencies. Student cell phones must remain off and in backpacks (this policy also applies to smart watches).

5. 1st Time Offense — Warning
6. 2nd Time Offense — Phone will be sent to the office for student pick up from the Principal
7. 3rd Time Offense — Phone will be sent to the office for student pick up from the Principal and parent will be notified

Room Parent & Parent Volunteers:

Ways to help: Chaperoning field trips, class parties (Halloween, Christmas, Valentine's, end-of-year), guest-speaking about science in your profession, sharing your job or hobby, and providing occasional lab supplies.

How to sign up: Please email me if you'd like to help — I'll connect you with our room parent. All volunteers must have current safe-environment training on file with the school office.

Key dates to remember: Back-to-School Night, Parent-Teacher Conferences (Q1 & Q3), All Saints Prayer Service, Christmas Program, Catholic Schools Week, STEM Fair, Field Day, and end-of-year Awards. Exact dates are on the school calendar and in weekly newsletters.

How to Support Your Child at Home:

- Routines: Build a consistent homework time and a distraction-free study spot.
- Read the news together and talk about the science behind current events (weather, earthquakes, animals, engineering).
- Independence: Let your child pack their own backpack and check the assignment sheet — mistakes are how we learn.
- Growth mindset: Praise effort and strategy ("I saw you keep trying") more than just results.
- Communication: Check Beehively weekly with your student. Celebrate wins and unpack misses together.
- Real-world science: Point out science in cooking, gardening, hikes, weather, and Hawaii's unique ecosystems.
- Contact me early if something at home or school is affecting learning — small course-corrections are much easier than late-quarter recoveries.

Important Dates:

- Parent Orientation Night: August 12, 2026
- Parent-Teacher Conferences: Fall — Sept. 10–11, 2026 · Spring — Feb. 19, 2027 (optional)
- Expeditions: Q1 Coconut Island (10/2), Q2 Pearl Harbor (11/16 pending) & Ice Palace (12/14), Q3 'Iolani Palace (3/5), Q4 Sherwood Forest (6/1 pending)
- School Spelling Bee: November 20, 2026
- Christmas Performance: December 18, 2026
- End-of-Year Awards: June 3, 2027

**All expeditions are subject to change at this point in the school year :)*

ACADEMIC INTEGRITY:

Honesty and integrity are essential values in our classroom. Teachers have the responsibility to:

- Structure conditions during testing to alleviate the possibility of cheating
- Specify the types of collaboration that are discouraged and those that are encouraged
- Teach students summarization of material and the distinction between summarizing and copying straight from the text

Students have the responsibility to:

- Avoid situations that might contribute to cheating or plagiarizing

- Avoid unauthorized assistance
- Use sources in the prescribed manner outlined by the teacher

ABSENCES AND TARDINESS:

Students may remain at home in the case of illness, accident, quarantine, or a death in the family. The teacher will help the student make up missing assignments after a short absence. When the absence is expected to be prolonged, families must notify the teacher so a plan can be developed.

Students are marked tardy after the 7:45 a.m. bell rings. Explanatory notes from parents and conferences with parents may be advisable.

FOOD AND DRINK:

- Food is prohibited in the classroom unless otherwise specified by the teacher.
- Drink in the classroom is limited to water in a bottle with a sealed lid.
- Sharing food is not permitted to ensure adherence to dietary restrictions.

TEACHER CONTACT:

Contact me via email: nbekers@starofthesea.org (please allow up to 24 hours for a response on school days)

4th Grade Team: 4thgradeteachers@starofthesea.org

In-person office hours: 2:45-3:15 p.m. (M-F) in Room B23

Mary, Star of the Sea School, 4469 Malia Street, Honolulu, Hawai'i 96821

Final Notes & Parent Acknowledgment:

Thank you for partnering with me this year. Your support at home is the single biggest factor in your child's confidence and success in science. I am grateful for the trust you place in Mary, Star of the Sea and in this classroom.

Class website: <https://starofthesea.org/classes/>

Parent Acknowledgment: After reviewing this syllabus with your student, please email nbekers@starofthesea.org with the subject line "Grade 4 Science Syllabus Reviewed — [Student Name]" so I know it has reached your family. Mahalo!

Empowered to Succeed, Guided by Faith ♥!